

force and authority without having to resort to such harsh punishment," says Major-General Surjit Singh (retired). It was perhaps the new Army chief's way of sending out a strong message that corruption won't be tolerated. Now, from his imposing teak-panelled office in South Block, it sounds like a promise: "We will ensure that the organisation remains clean and good."

It is perhaps a tribute to his personal integrity and scrupulously honest reputation that even one of the generals he acted against (and who declined to be named) calls him a fine soldier. His course mates say he had been earmarked for generalship early on in his career. As a young officer in 1976, Singh topped the elite Rangers Course in the US, despite being among the older officers on the course. The extremely intense two-month training is among the world's most physically taxing combat leadership courses. The few that make the grade are put through an eight-week grinder which sees them do speed marches with 25 kg backpack loads in the mountains of Georgia and swamps of Florida. "It toughens you and gives you the strength to go on despite severe physical and mental hardships," says General Singh, who still sports the prestigious black and yellow Rangers patch on his left arm.

Yet, despite his impeccable personal achievements, Singh is an enigma—extremely low key, media shy and simple to the point of being austere, a fitness freak, vegetarian and a teetotaler. He evidently never let his outspokenness come in the way of a meteoric rise even as he aced all his courses and held unusual billets like commanding the Ambala-based 2 Corps, an elite unit normally commanded by armoured corps officers. He shares an excellent rapport with the last man down the line and could often be spotted kicking a football around with his soldiers or working out in the command gym in Fort William.

Being the Army chief is an entirely new challenge. Despite the image of a sweeping all-powerful entity, the reality is of power that is shared with South Block's civilian bureaucracy. The Army chief cannot, for instance, procure equipment, raise the size of the army or alter the wage structure. He cannot redeploy troops without formal approval from the Cabinet Committee on Security. "A good chief is someone who can identify the areas where he can make a difference and implement them," says a senior army officer.

Good chiefs have made a difference in their brief tenures either by spending time in the Military

army has a rich tradition and value system base," he emphasises. These are truisms but in the light of recent events of corruption, they bear repetition from the chief. His next priority is modernisation and enhancing military preparedness though he admits modernisation is a long-drawn out process which will take longer than just his tenure to fix. "Preparedness is a sum of several other factors including training, not just weapons and equipment," he says. Military training, which he promises to make more practical, is one of his other challenges.

His current read, *The Sling and the Stone*, on the changing face of war

"We have to build on the Indian Army's core competencies like selflessness and professionalism."

GENERAL V.K. SINGH, Army Chief



Operations Directorate, tweaking offensive, defensive and posture plans like General K. Sunderji over two decades ago, building a fence that helped cut infiltration into Jammu & Kashmir like General N.C. Vij or simply travel around and motivate soldiers by sheer charisma like Field Marshal Sam Manekshaw. Training and military intelligence are two other critical areas where a chief can make a difference. Singh is yet to deliver his vision statement but has hinted that the challenge begins at home. "We have to build on our strengths and core competencies like selflessness and professionalism. The

in the 21st century, probably hints at how far warfare has changed since he was commissioned into the Army in June 1970. He was thrown into combat in the 1971 Bangladesh liberation war as a Second Lieutenant as part of the Indian Army's dash into Chittagong. Later, he saw action while deployed with his Rajput regiment in Sri Lanka during Operation Pawan in 1987 and counter-insurgency stints in Jammu & Kashmir. Yet, despite four decades in the Army, home is always Bapora where he spends every vacation. "It's good to be always connected to the earth," he smiles.